

Preparing your First Resume

'First impression is the last impression'. This oft-repeated saying is very true when a prospective employer opens your CV for the first time. A well-written and well-formatted resume is leagues ahead of a poorly formatted, badly written one. Make sure you present yourself well.

Know that your resume is you. If it contains spelling and grammar mistakes, it automatically means you don't know any better. After all, you are applying for a career in technical writing. Check and double-check (and one more time, if possible) before you send your applications anywhere.

Don't ever be too wordy or verbose in your presentation of yourself. Vanity kills and your resume is not your autobiography. One of the basic qualities of a technical writer is to be clear and concise when expressing something—apply this principle to perfection in your CV. And please don't overdo anything.

A word to people with previous working experience looking to switch over: Since you have experience, mention the type of work you've been doing. Also mention previous experience with writing, if any, and the tools and software you are familiar with, besides the number of years you've put in your previous jobs.

work towards your advantage. RoboHelp is more widely used than ForeHelp and is more in demand. Knowledge of Microsoft FrontPage will also prove to be advantageous.

Thinking of shifting already? Wait a second and take a look at the remaining points to get an idea of how to make a seamless career switch.

Stage three: The educational aspect

There are several universities abroad that offer graduate and higher-level courses in technical writing. However, our country boasts of no such universities or courses. Private institutions such



Successful technical writing is the result of knowing how to structure information in words and in visual design

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as Technowrites in Pune and Deldot systems in Bangalore offer certified courses in technical writing. Indian National Scientific Documentation Centre (INSDOC) in New Delhi also offers courses in documentation.

What is the best way to learn more about your job? Read more books! Utilise the Internet and visit forums where you can learn more from other's experiences.

Are you Hiding a Writer?

Check list to find out if there is a technical writer hidden inside you:

- Can you reduce complex technology to simple logic for others to understand?
 - Do you get overly affected by spelling mistakes and grammatical bloopers?
 - Can you scan a large, uninteresting product brochure in five minutes for the meaningful?
 - Is having a discussion on technology your idea of a perfect evening?
 - Do you look for the Science and Technology page of the newspaper before the headlines?
- If you've answered yes to at least three of these questions, there is a budding technical writer inside you. Nurture him. And fix him a date with other technical writers in your colony.

Stage four: The first job

Let us be blunt and frank about this. The first technical writing job is difficult to get. This is primarily due to the fact that many Indian companies prefer people with experience. You need to prove that you can write, and that you understand technology, more than anything else.

Savita, a technical writer at eVector solutions, has some expert advice for those hunting for their first jobs. "Watch out for job postings in the twin-india.org site/newspapers. You can subscribe to the TWIN list by sending a mail to twin@user.itconsult.co.uk. For the first job you

need to show your writing skills as well as the ability to understand technology. The best way is to send some samples of your writings. Most companies have their own standard interview/test patterns which include a test of English language, technical tests, and so on".

Remember: The lesser a company has to spend on your training, the sooner it will hire you. If you are language-savvy and already know the various Word processing tools, consider the job half done.

Prospective employers often ask for a sample of your technical writing. If you do not have a sample, make one. This will give you a good idea of what the job involves as well as an insight into the various factors (and difficulties) involved in technical writing. "Try to find a short, badly written manual and re-write it. Then have the original and the re-written manual as the proof to your abilities"—this is Sajitha's suggestion. If you are attempting this, take the original with you for the interview so that the interviewer gets to see the difference.

To know what the technical writing process consists of, remember the acronym POWER, which stands for Planning, Organising, Writing, Editing and Revising. Follow these five steps diligently while working on your first written work to get a professional result. How soon you get a job would depend on how well you write.

You can also join an organisation as an intern. This will help you make contacts in the field and gain valuable experiences at the same time. Usually, companies recruit interns who show aptitude in becoming good technical writers.

It wouldn't be wrong to presume that you are interested in a career in technical writing if you've read this far. Try this option. It gives you a chance to write, to be creative and to do what you love doing the most: bringing technology closer to the masses. ■